allowed the media freer dissemination of news and people free expression of their opinions. With glasnost, Soviet citizens no longer had to worry about arrest and exile for articulating negative opinions against the State. These ideas created a revolutionary wave of liberalism in Soviet Union. At the same time, it eventually led to the disintegration of Soviet Union.



Boris Yeltsin



Jimmy Carter

1989 was a watershed year in the Cold War era. Free elections were conducted in Poland. The Polish Solidarity movement won the election, routing the Communists. In July Gorbachev, speaking at the Council of Europe, remarked that he rejected the Brezhnev Doctrine: "Any interference in domestic affairs and any attempts to restrict the sovereignty of states, both friends and allies or any others, are inadmissible." In November 1989, one of the most famous symbols of the Cold War, the Berlin Wall came down. In late November 1989 West German Chancellor Helmut Kohl, without consulting any allies, suddenly announced a ten-point programme calling for free elections in East Germany and the eventual "German reunification". By the end of the 1989 a popular uprising took place in Eastern Europe and most of the leaders were ousted except in Bulgaria. Slowly Eastern Europe severed its affiliation with communism. This was taken as a clue by many Soviet Republics and by mid-1990 many of them declared themselves as independent states. On December 8, 1991, the Soviet Union disintegrated. On 25th December Gorbachev resigned, Boris Yeltsin became the President of the Russian Republic. With the disintegration of USSR the Cold War came to an end.

Boris Yeltsin (1931–2007): Joining the Communist Party in 1961, Yeltsin became a full-time worker in the party in 1968. In the seventies he emerged as a popular figure and began to occupy in key positions in the Party. After Gorbachev came to power, he chose Yeltsin (1985) to eliminate corruption in the Moscow party organisation. In 1986 Yeltsin was elevated to the Politburo (the highest policy making body of the Soviet Union). Soon he was made the mayor of Moscow. Yeltsin antagonised Gorbachev when he began criticising the slow pace of reform at party meetings. His popularity with the people grew as he advocated democratisation of governance and economic reform. He succeeded in winning a seat in the USSR Congress of People's Deputies (the new Soviet Parliament) in March 1989. A year later, on May 29, 1990, the Soviet parliament elected him president of the Russian republic against Gorbachev's wishes. He became the first popularly elected leader in 1991, after the collapse of Soviet Union.

Summary

- The devastated economy of Western Europe in the aftermath of Second World War and the emergence of bi-polar world with US and USSR emerging as super powers are explained.
- Strategies of the competing super powers to establish hegemony through measures of economic aid and military pacts are discussed.
- Marshall Plan of the US and the USSR's Moltov Plan as a response, the formation of NATO and signing of Warsaw Pact by Soviet Union with its satellite countries to counteract the former's offensive are highlighted.

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